

Out OF THE BOX

The squeamishness about pornography as couples therapy is an offshoot of the belief that sex is purely for reproduction not pleasure. Vatsyayana, India's oldest sexologist, would not have been happy.

| By Rita Banerji |

"Is she cooking or seducing?" a friend commented on Nigella Lawson, the ravishing cooking hostess on *Travel and Living*. I had never thought of it that way. But now I saw it—Nigella's seductive voice, the way she flirts with the camera, even the suggestive manner in which she puts food into her mouth—it does have a feel of soft porn. The TRPs must be shooting through the roof. Housewives love her for transforming cooking into a sexy, glamorous pursuit, instead of the sweaty, thankless job it is. And men who couldn't identify an onion without its jacket, are probably fumbling with their aprons, to pant after her into the kitchen. Well, at least as voyeuristic couch-cooks.

My mother who overheard our conversation, objected vigorously. Nigella and porn? Impossible. The thing is, she likes Nigella, and nothing mom likes can be pornographic. It is really more an indictment on her than on Nigella. After all, mom is not "that type" of a person. The type that her old Chambers 20th Century Dictionary makes an oblique reference to, when it describes pornography as "obscene writing, painting, and the like". Contemplating INDIA TODAY-AC-Nielsen-ORG-MARG 2009 sex survey data, I wondered if much of urban India too uses the same dictionary. Only 27 per cent of women respondents admit to having watched porn films. And only 4 per cent more who haven't, would like to. However, a majority of the women, 66 per cent, not only claim ignorance about pornographic films or its uses, but also do not wish to try watching them with their partners.

